Responsible Administrator: VP Student Affairs
Responsible Office: Dean of Students
Effective Date: 02/09/2021
Approved by: President
Date of Revision: 02/09/2021
Date Reviewed (no substantive changes): 02/18/2026

Student Complaint Policy

Policy Statement

The University has procedures in place to address written student complaints. A complaint is an unresolved issue or problem related to the student's future, current or past enrollment at the University. Complaints may involve grades, finances, auxiliary activities (e.g., campus housing or dining services), recognized organizations, treatment by faculty/staff or other students, the code of student conduct or other matters related to student enrollment.

Purpose of Policy

The purpose of this policy is to provide a safe and organized way for students to express complaints and seek redress. This policy complies with the policies and standards of SACSCOC.

Applicability

Future, current, or past Southeastern students.

Policy Procedure

The Dean of Students serves as the official Student Ombudsperson, investigating student complaints in clarifying University policy, advocating on behalf of students, making student referrals, helping define available options; and recommending changes to University policies, rules, or procedures that are outdated, unclear, or ineffective.

Most student complaints are addressed through well-established appeal processes and are initiated by the student with the relevant University office, e.g., academic grade appeals begin with the instructor of the course, financial aid appeals begin with the Office of Financial Aid, admissions appeals begin with the Admissions Office, housing appeals begin with the Office of University Housing, etc. Each office that administers an established appeal process publishes the information about the process on their webpage.

The Dean of Students serves as the official clearing house for all student complaints that are not submitted directly by the student to the appropriate office that will handle the complaint. As such, student complaints submitted to the Dean of Students will be referred to the appropriate appeal process and individual/office that has authority over the issue, e.g., a student who has a complaint about a grade will be provided the grade appeal process and referred to the instructor of the course. Other complaints that may not be associated with an established appeal process are referred to the appropriate administrative office. For example, a student who has a complaint about a faculty member that does not involve a grade would be referred to the faculty member's department head.

Generally, unresolved complaints that fall outside of established appeal processes may advance up the organizational line and are considered final at the level of the relevant vice president. As provided in policies associated with specific appeal processes, some appeals may advance to the president of the University, and in limited circumstances, to the Board of Supervisors, e.g., disciplinary expulsion.

Student complaints become official when submitted in writing. The relevant University offices that receive and process student complaints are required to maintain logs of all written complaints and the resulting resolution. University officials who address student complaints are expected to periodically review the complaint logs for patterns that may indicate University policies or operations which may need to be reviewed and modified. As the Student Ombudsperson and official clearinghouse for student complaints, the Dean of Students is uniquely positioned to help the University identify patterns of student complaints that may suggest policies or operations which need modification.

[End of Policy]